

01a 4 Beliefs about Church-Owned Bible Translation – Walkthrough

(Slide deck; COBT Module 1a Exercise; white board recommended – 60 min. discussion on 4 Beliefs and 30 min. for Exercise.)

Intro: In the last session, we talked about how Wycliffe Associates offers free training and tools so that we can equip and train partners in Church-Owned Bible Translation.

Ask: What do you think “Church-Owned” Bible Translation means?

- Make a list of what they share on white board or easel.
(Note: Their suggested elements may be a good starting point for the later conversation about Quality Assessment.)
- Reveal our organizational beliefs about **Ability – Authority – Responsibility – Accountability** via white board or slide deck.
(Note similarities with their suggestions and do some Q&A about the differences. This is primarily to get the ideas planted.)
 - **Ability** – The local believers of a language community understand their language and culture better than an outsider; typically, at least some people are multilingual, so they have skill in sharing meaning through oral translation. (Bilingual speakers have shared meaning through oral translation most of their lives.) Additionally, their previous knowledge of more than one language, without having to spend years learning a new one, sets these believers up to begin translating right away. God gives each one unique gifts for the teamwork of the body (Romans 12:4–6a; 2 Timothy 2:7).
 - Have trainees ever overheard someone who shares their heart language translate something from another language into their heart language? How well did he communicate the same message?
 - Have they ever heard an outsider translate something from his own language into their heart language? How well did he communicate the same message?
 - Which is easier for them: translating into their heart language or from their heart language to their second language?
 - **Authority** – God’s Spirit resides in every believer. He provides wisdom and gives each believer authority to share, teach, or translate God’s Word according to the specific abilities and opportunities God has given to that believer (Matthew 28:18–20; Acts 1:8).
 - How do they understand authority? What does authority include in their culture? *(Ideas: the right to make decisions, the right to tell people what to do, the right to change things, the right to start new things, etc.)*

- **Responsibility** – The local Church bears the responsibility for: Evangelism – Discipleship – Bible Translation (1 Peter 3:15; Colossians 3:16; 2 Timothy 2:2).
 - What areas are included in responsibility for the translation? (*Ideas: overseeing the process, ensuring progress, seeking outside help, making decisions on quality*)
- **Accountability** – Mother-tongue translators are accountable to God and to their community for the accuracy, clarity, and accessibility of Scripture in their heart language (Romans 14:12; 1 Corinthians 2:12–13).
 - How much more effective can evangelism, discipleship, and church planting be when the Church owns Scripture in the heart language of the people?

Exercise Session (Beliefs) Scenario Match

(Time will vary depending on group size, but 30 to 40 min. should be a good target.)

- Gauge the size of the gathering and assign groups to tables with a presenter at each if necessary.
- Prepare for the **COBT Module 1a Exercise** with the following scenario/ Impact Story, and have the team choose the Belief(s) to best match it.
 - **Example:** The Ontenu People of Papua New Guinea were clashing violently with neighboring clans. Despite the conflict, their church leaders decided to attend a WA translation workshop. During the workshop, their village was raided, and half the homes were burned. The translators chose to keep working, rather than to join the fight. At the end of the workshop, the Ontenu leaders had translated more Scripture than any of the other 4 language groups present.
 - This is a good example of **Responsibility** because the translators followed God's calling despite the challenges they faced.

*(Note: This can also fit other beliefs like **Ability** or **Authority**, but the trainees must be able to explain why it fits their choice.)*
- Break participants up into smaller groups and complete **COBT Module 1a Exercise**.
- Come back together and discuss their ideas.

Confirm: The translators understand the four beliefs about COBT and have considered how those beliefs apply to their local Church.

***Trainer's Note:** When taken as a whole, these concepts can be challenging to understand for new partners—especially when considered in the context of the colonial missions model many have become accustomed to. Be sure to dig in and find any doubts, fears, or areas that need clarification. Address these issues with the leaders now, so that they may address them later with their local translation teams.